

**Acer Cloud**

After acquiring iGware, a company offering cloud software and infrastructure tools, Acer has announced Acer Cloud which will begin operations in late September

**LaCie Rugged Mini**

LaCie Rugged Mini is a USB 3 portable drive with five layers of protection that makes it scratch, rain and water resistant

# What's in Store?

With portable drives becoming the preferred mode of carrying around your data, we decided to pit the best against each other to help you select the best one for your needs.



Nimish Sawant

[nimish.sawant.thinkdigit.com](http://nimish.sawant.thinkdigit.com)

Last year when we had done the External Hard drive comparison test, we noticed two trends. Companies were raising the capacities along with affordable pricing. Second was that most of the drives had impressive designs. This year has seen a new technology emerge, which should comfortably become mainstream by the next time we have a comparison test.

We are talking about the USB 3.0 technology which has a theoretical transfer rate of 5 Gbps as opposed to the theoretical speeds of 480 Mbps offered by USB 2.0. Where we

had just one USB 3.0 drive in our last comparison, this one has over 15 drives which are USB 3.0 compatible. Another thing we noticed is that you no longer need to use your power supply if you are using a 1TB portable drive. Designs are getting impressive but at the same time companies are offering backup and encryption utilities to differentiate their offerings. So let's just start off with the drives.

## USB 3.0 drives

Last year we had received just one USB 3.0 drive for the comparison test and it had come with a USB 3.0 adapter. Now almost every other motherboard has a USB 3.0 port. Also the prices of these drives

are becoming affordable. We received 14 drives from nine different brands, which were more than the USB 2.0 drives

Silicon Power sent us three drives namely the Diamond D10 (750 GB), Armor A80 (640GB) and Stream S10 (750 GB). Design wise, they were as different as chalk and cheese, with the Stream S10 looking the smartest with its race-car like form factor and bright colors. The Armor A80 as the name suggests is a rugged drive which seems bulky when compared to the other two, but it is waterproof and shock-proof. It comes with two USB 3.0 cables, one is an extremely short one, ideal for laptops and the other is a longer cable. The Diamond D10 has com-

pact form factor and a glossy chequered design. The Silicon Power drives offer you the SP Widget which is a utility which can be downloaded from their website that offers data encryption, data and email backup and backup of your My Favorites folder, etc.

Seagate's GoFlex Slim is one drive that left us quite impressed with its slim profile and great transfer speeds thanks to the 7200 RPM drive within it. Although at 320GB it was the lowest capacity portable drive in this category. The other USB 3.0 drive from Seagate was the highest capacity portable drive at 1.5TB which came in a piano black glossy finish. Though it may not win any slim awards,